What kind of building

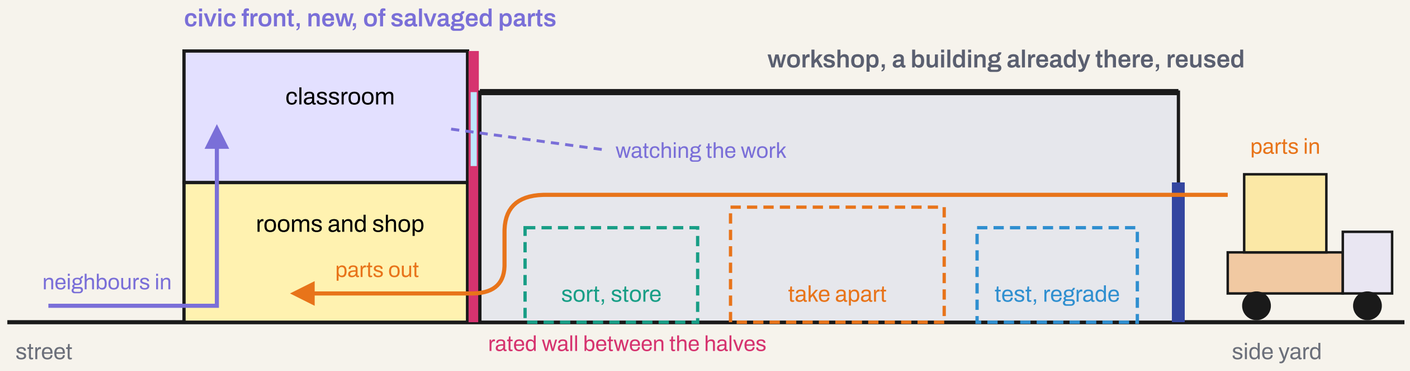
Is the hub an institution, an industrial building, a conversion, or something new on an empty lot? It is two buildings joined: a workshop, which is industrial, in a low building that already stands near the houses; and a community centre, which is civic, added along the street from salvaged parts.

2
buildings joined: a workshop and a community centre

5 of 6
candidate sites have a low, large building nearby

3 of 6
have one big enough for a whole hub

The answer, in section



Schematic, not to scale; the programme and where each part sits are first thoughts, not a layout. No building, site or operator is chosen. The rated wall separates an industrial occupancy from assembly and mercantile ones, which also makes the two halves legible.

Workshop

The slow work that does not need the house's site: testing and regrading wood, taking components apart by hand, repair, sorting by lifespan and condition, and storage. A clear span, a roller door, a yard for a lorry, an enclosed room. In code terms, industrial.

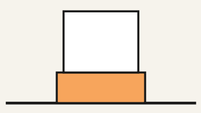
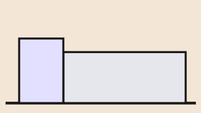
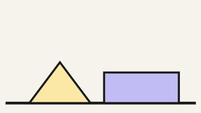
Community centre

What a multiplex block lacks: rooms neighbours share. A café and a grocery, rooms for culture and exhibition, the shop that offers the parts, and a classroom that looks into the work. In code terms, assembly and mercantile.

Reuse first

The workshop moves into a store, garage or warehouse already there; the front is added from salvaged parts, so the hub shows what it does in how it is built. Where nothing stands, it is built new as a kit on the same plan. Both halves come apart: when a neighbourhood's houses have turned over, the front moves on and the shed goes back to another use.

Four ways to house it

	 A. New, on a cleared lot	 B. Under new housing	 C. Reuse a low building, add a civic front	 D. On a waiting site, for a few years
Carbon	○ All new: the embodied carbon this project argues against.	○ New, shared with the housing above.	● Keeps the shell and frame; only the front is added, from salvage.	● A kit of salvaged parts; little new.
Land and time	○ Buys land at city prices.	○ Waits on a developer's project.	● A lease on commercial or industrial land.	◐ Cheapest, but case by case and time-limited.
The heavy work	● Designed for it.	○ Dust, noise and lorries below homes.	● Clear span, loading, an enclosed room.	◐ Tents and containers, at the weather's mercy.
A public face near the houses	● Good on an arterial.	● Good.	● Good, once the front is added.	◐ Fair.
Long enough for a community centre	● Yes.	● Yes.	● For the term of a lease.	○ Years, not decades.
Fit with the thesis	○ A new permanent object.	○ Poor.	● A building reconfigured, with a front made to come apart.	◐ Good, but short.
Near the six candidate sites	◐ Needs a cleared lot.	◐ Needs a developer.	● At five of six (below).	◐ Depends on vacant City sites.
Verdict	Only where nothing stands, and then as a kit.	Not for the workshop; perhaps a small front room.	**The default.**	A way to start: a pilot while a lease is found.

● good ◐ fair ○ poor, against the talk's own argument: carbon, the price of land, time on site, and the hub's two roles. Carbon and fit for the work decide.

Why reuse wins on carbon

The Preservation Green Lab's *The Greenest Building* found that reusing an average building almost always beats demolition and a more efficient new one, a saving that shrinks when a renovation needs many new materials; here the addition is a light front of salvaged parts. The City lists adaptive reuse first among its ways to keep building waste out of landfill.

Why a plain shed

Stewart Brand's “low road” buildings, plain and cheap, are the ones their users change most freely; old warehouses are his recurring example. A hub's work changes with what arrives each week, so it belongs in a low-road building, not a precious one.

Why not under housing

Vancouver delivers many community rooms in the base of new towers. A workshop with saws, lorries and stored wood sits badly below homes, and it would tie the hub to a developer's timing.

What reuse centres occupy

Almost every reuse centre I found lives in a building it did not build. None joins a workshop to a neighbourhood community centre: that pairing is the proposal.

Industrial sheds and stores

Rotor DC
Brussels, cooperative
A former chocolate factory lent by a public developer, 2017–2022; now a depot in Evere.
A public owner can lend a waiting building.

ReBuilding Center
Portland, non-profit
A warehouse store of about 30,000 sq ft, its front clad by volunteers in donated salvage.
A reused shed with a salvage front; the size used here for a whole hub.

Rebuilding Exchange
Chicago, non-profit
A warehouse with a retail floor, deconstruction services and a trades apprenticeship.
Training belongs with the work.

Salvage Lumber Warehouse
Seattle, public, 2026
A SoDo warehouse run by Earthwise for Seattle Public Utilities.
A city can own the problem; lumber needs a roof.

Habitat ReStores
Metro Vancouver
Industrial units in Burnaby, Abbotsford, Chilliwack and Langley; none in the City.
The local norm: a store far from the houses that supply it.

Large buildings that lost their use

CRCLR House
Berlin, 2020–23
A brewery warehouse kept and extended, a timber gallery splitting the hall.
Closest parti: an old shed, a new gallery inside.

BlueCity
Rotterdam
A vacant 12,000 m² swimming complex, converted from 2015 with reused parts.
A building that lost its use becomes a circular hub.

K.118
Winterthur, 2021
Three storeys of reused parts added on a former factory block.
Design from found parts, on a building kept.

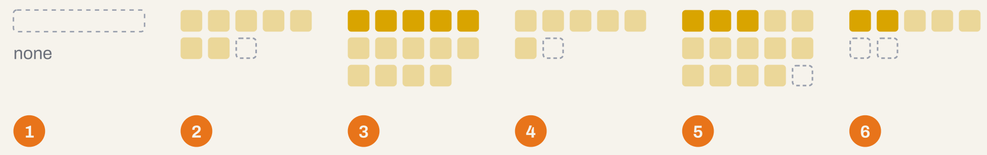
Haus der Materialisierung
Berlin
An open materials archive inside a 1960s office block once slated for demolition.
Option D at full scale: a meanwhile use.

No building

BauKarussell
Vienna, cooperative
Social enterprises take buildings apart by hand, on site.
The labour model; the hub gives such crews a roof.

Is there a building to reuse near each site?

Low, large buildings within 400 m of each of the six rule-based sites (print 4): a footprint of 600 m² or more, 12 m or less, on industrial or commercial-arterial land. Each one found in the City's footprints was checked against its 2026 property assessment and against demolition permits: 46 of 51 still stand.



■ standing, big enough for a whole hub, about 2,800 m² (the ReBuilding Center's store) ■ standing, smaller: part of a hub, or two together ▢ found in 2009–15, not confirmed today

Site	Found, 2009–15	Standing, 2026	Whole-hub size	Largest still standing	Nearest, m
1. Kaslo St at Venables St	0	0	0	none	–
2. Victoria Dr at E 48th Ave	8	7	0	2010 E 48th Ave, 2,380 m², built 1973	20
3. West Blvd at W 39th Ave	14	14	5	2146 W 41st Ave, 4,829 m², built 1920	35
4. Dunbar St at W 17th Ave	7	6	0	3628 W 16th Ave, 1,632 m², built 1926	45
5. Main St at E 29th Ave	15	14	3	4276 Main St, 4,316 m², built 1947	37
6. Victoria Dr at the Diversion	7	5	2	3586 Commercial St, 4,653 m², built 1991	75

Three sites (West Boulevard, Main Street, the Victoria Diversion) have one big enough for a whole hub; two have mid-size ones; Kaslo Street has none, so a hub there is built new as a kit or moves. This narrows the Site and Program choice on 18 November; it does not make it.

Found in the City's 2009 and 2015 footprints; confirmed where the parcel's 2026 assessment shows a building built before 2016 with an improvement value of at least $100,000, and no demolition permit since 2016. Two had demolition permits; three could not be confirmed. Full list, with addresses: data/siting/existing-stock-checked.csv. Kinds of building to look for, not properties for sale or lease. Scripts: build/hub_stock.py, build/hub_stock_check.py.

To check with the City

Zoning

Five sites are C-2A and one M-1. C-2 asks commercial uses to stay within a completely enclosed building, which suits indoor work. A salvage workshop is not clearly any listed use (“Recycling Depot” excludes a junk yard or shop), so the first step is the Director of Planning's discretion; a rezoning may still be needed.

Building code

Mixed major occupancies: assembly (A-2) for the classroom and rooms, mercantile (E) for the shop, industrial (likely F-2) for the workshop and its stored wood. Table 3.1.3.1 sets the separations, to confirm with a code consultant; a classroom that looks into the work needs rated glazing.

Interim use (option D)

No single interim-use policy found; CD-1 by-laws allow interim uses case by case if compatible, easy to remove, low in cost and intensity, and time-limited, in one 2022 draft to five-year permits.

Sources

Brand, *How Buildings Learn*, 1994; Preservation Green Lab, *The Greenest Building*, 2011.
City of Vancouver: C&D waste page; Green Demolition By-law; C-2 and C-2B schedules; CD-1 interim conditions; footprints 2009, 2015. BC Building Code 2024, Table 3.1.3.1.
Rotor; ReBuilding Center; Rebuilding Exchange; Seattle Public Utilities, 1 May 2026; BlueCity; CRCLR (zrs.berlin); K.118 (baubüro in situ); Haus der Statistik; BauKarussell; Habitat GV, ReStores and Rebuild Hub.